



“I COME FROM A COUNTRY AND A CIVILISATION THAT GAVE US THE UNIVERSAL WORD OM.”

RESUL POOKUTTY

over the offers from Hollywood. His commitments to the Indian film industries continue: while Anthony D'Souza's *Blue*, with a number composed for Kylie Minogue, is complete, so are the songs for Mani Ratnam's *Ravana*, and coming up are S. Shankar's *Endiran*, Rajiv Menon's *Dhun*, Rajnikant's animated *Sultan*, Abbas

photography with state of the art cameras—the latest is a Rs 5-lakh HD camera.

If Rahman seems utterly composed in the midst of all this frenzy, and yet be modest enough to be starstruck, it is because he has come close to this sort of fame several times before. When Andrew Lloyd Webber chose him to compose *Bombay Dreams*. Or when he was unable to work with Baz Luhrmann because his people saw the long list of projects next to his name on imdb.com. Or even when an album with American violinist Joshua Bell didn't work out with Sony Music.

His best work keeps getting better. Film scholar Nasreen Munni Kabir says she remembers Webber telling her how his melodies were exceptional. “Take the song *Rehna tu* in *Delhi-6*,” she says. “The depth of field creates great visual impact in cinema, and Rahman manages this in sound through the way he mixes his tracks. He composes in the language of film.”

And sometimes, as in *Slumdog Millionaire*, which he composed largely in his Tuffnel Park home in London, that language is catchy and anthemic. Pussycat Dolls have already done a remix version of *Jai ho* (*Jai ho! You are my destiny*) and Simon Beaufoy's neologism *slumdog* threatens to become part of the language. In a topsy-turvy world where rich banks are getting bailouts and poor nations are teaching the joys of thriftiness, where an African immigrant is urging America to rise in hope at the same time as a second generation Indian is making a play to be the Republican candidate for 2012, it is perfectly in sync for Hollywood razzle-dazzlers to be dancing to Rahman's tune. ■



AP PHOTO/MARK J. TERRILL

(CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT) RAHMAN PERFORMS AT THE OSCARS; POOKUTTY; THE CAST AND CREW OF *SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE*

vatory in Chennai is nurturing talented musicians. Rahman's ear has always been eclectic, picking up talents such as Ash King and Rashid Ali, whose album he is producing. And his worksheet is about to get a little more selective, as he mulls

Tyrewala's *1-800-LOVE* and *19th Step*. Within days of his coming back, Rahman will also be announcing a global concert, which will be spread over several months. But not before a break perhaps where he can indulge his passion for nature